

Turning 65 — Medicare Basics

What Nobody Told Your Client Before They Called You

The frank field guide for U.S. Medicare agents walking a Turning 65 prospect through the most important coverage decision of their life.

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■ KILL SWITCH — VERIFY BEFORE EVERY USE

- Part B standard premium 2026: \$202.90/month (up 9.7% from \$185 in 2025). Verify at cms.gov.
- Part A inpatient hospital deductible 2026: \$1,736 per benefit period. Verify at cms.gov.
- Part B annual deductible 2026: \$283. Verify at cms.gov.
- Part D average standalone premium 2026: ~\$46.50/month. Verify at cms.gov.
- IEP timing rules: consistent, but always confirm no legislative changes at medicare.gov.
- IRMAA surcharge brackets change annually for higher-income beneficiaries. Verify at cms.gov.

"People don't think about Medicare until it's time. And when it's time, they're overwhelmed. They've heard things from neighbors, read something on the news, and half of what they think they know is wrong. You are not just their agent. You are their guide. Act like it."

EDUCATING LIKE AN ELDER — YOUR MOST POWERFUL TOOL

The most effective Medicare agents don't sell — they teach. Think about how a wise elder gives advice: they speak plainly, they warn you about the traps, they tell you what to watch for, and they make you feel safe enough to ask the questions you were embarrassed to ask. That is your role in every Turning 65 appointment. Not a salesperson. Not a product pusher. A trusted guide.

- SEASONED AGENT TIP: Open every Turning 65 appointment with: 'Let me just walk you through how this actually works — because there's a lot of misinformation out there, and I want to make sure you have the right picture.' Watch them exhale. Then walk them through it.

THE 4 PARTS OF U.S. MEDICARE — EXPLAINED LIKE A HUMAN BEING

Part	Name	What It Covers	2026 Cost (Kill Switch)
A	Hospital	Inpatient hospital, skilled nursing facility, hospice, some home health	Usually \$0 premium (40+ Medicare work quarters). Deductible: \$1,736/benefit period.
B	Medical	Doctor visits, outpatient services, preventive care, lab work, durable medical equipment	\$202.90/month standard. Higher-income beneficiaries pay IRMAA surcharge.
C	Medicare Advantage	Private insurer bundles Parts A + B; often includes Part D and extras like dental/vision	Varies by plan. Some \$0 premium. Network-based.
D	Prescription Drugs	Outpatient Rx coverage through CMS-approved private insurers	Avg ~\$46.50/month standalone. Varies by plan and zip code.

Kill Switch: All figures verified from CMS November 2025 announcement. Verify annually at [cms.gov](https://www.cms.gov).

THE 7-MONTH IEP WINDOW — AND WHY MISSING IT IS CATASTROPHIC

The Initial Enrollment Period is 7 months: the 3 months before the birthday month, the birthday month itself, and the 3 months after. For most Americans turning 65, this is the most consequential insurance deadline of their lives. Miss it without qualifying coverage in place and they face permanent penalties on Part B and Part D — added to their premiums every month for the rest of their Medicare life.

■ **FIELD WARNING: The Part B late enrollment penalty is 10% added to the premium for every 12-month period missed — permanently. Combined with a Part D LEP, a client who missed their IEP without creditable coverage could pay hundreds of extra dollars per year indefinitely. There is no appeal process for the standard LEP. Educate. Every. Client.**

THE 5 SCENARIOS YOU WILL FACE MOST OFTEN

Still working — employer coverage, 20+ employee company

They can delay Part B without penalty as long as they have active employer coverage from a company with 20+ employees. But the moment that coverage ends — retirement, job loss, COBRA — they have 8 months to enroll in Part B under a Special Enrollment Period. That 8-month clock is not negotiable. Get it in writing from their HR department that the coverage qualifies.

Retiring at 65 or before — your primary client

This is the appointment that defines your book of business. They're leaving employer coverage and need to choose a path. Take the time to walk them through both options — Original Medicare + Supplement + Part D, or Medicare Advantage. Don't rush this appointment. They will remember the agent who sat with them and explained it clearly. That's how you build referrals that last 20 years.

Already collecting Social Security

Good news: they're automatically enrolled in Medicare Parts A and B. Their card arrives in the mail about 3 months before their birthday month. Bad news: many assume Medicare comes with drug coverage. It does not. They still need to choose a Part D plan and decide on supplement or Medicare Advantage coverage.

On COBRA — the dangerous scenario

This is where agents see clients get blindsided. COBRA is NOT creditable coverage for the purpose of delaying Part B enrollment. A client who retires, takes COBRA, and assumes they've 'handled Medicare' will discover their mistake when they try to enroll and face a permanent Part B penalty. Be direct with every COBRA client: you still need to enroll in Part B during your IEP.

Veterans with VA coverage only

VA benefits do not satisfy the creditable coverage requirement for Medicare Part D. Veterans who delay Part D enrollment while relying solely on VA drug benefits will face a Late Enrollment Penalty if they later want a standalone Part D plan. Always have this conversation with veteran clients — and document it.

THE TWO PATHS — HOW TO PRESENT THE CHOICE WITHOUT CONFUSION

Path	What It Is	Best For	What to Watch For
Original Medicare + Medigap + Part D	Government runs Parts A and B. Private Medigap fills the gaps. Separate Part D for drugs.	Clients who want freedom to see any Medicare provider nationwide. Predictable out-of-pocket costs.	Higher total monthly premium. Must apply for Medigap during OEP or face medical underwriting.
Medicare Advantage (Part C)	CMS-approved private insurer bundles A + B + usually D + supplemental benefits.	Clients who want lower premiums, extra benefits like dental and vision, and are comfortable with provider networks.	Network restrictions. Prior authorizations. Benefits and premiums can change every January 1.

"I tell clients: think of Original Medicare like building your own plate at a buffet — you choose every piece. Medicare Advantage is the set meal — it comes with a lot, but you eat what they serve. Neither is wrong. It depends on who you are and how you live."

VERIFIED U.S. RESOURCES & CITATIONS

Medicare & You 2025 Handbook (CMS)

<https://www.medicare.gov/Pubs/pdf/10050-Medicare-and-You.pdf>

The official CMS client education handbook. Keep copies to leave at Turning 65 appointments.

CMS 2026 Parts A & B Premiums & Deductibles

<https://www.cms.gov/newsroom/fact-sheets/2026-medicare-parts-b-premiums-deductibles>

KILL SWITCH: Official source for all 2026 cost figures. Verify before every client conversation.

Medicare.gov — When to Sign Up

<https://www.medicare.gov/basics/get-started-with-medicare/sign-up/when-to-sign-up-for-medicare>

CMS enrollment timing guide. Share with every Turning 65 prospect.

SSA Medicare Enrollment Portal

<https://www.ssa.gov/medicare/>

For clients collecting Social Security or enrolling directly through SSA.

Medicare Plan Finder

<https://www.medicare.gov/plan-compare/>

Compare all Part C and Part D plans by zip code and drug list.

YOUR NEXT STEP: AgentRisePro

The Medicare Agent Workspace built by a 25-year U.S. Medicare field veteran — for U.S. agents who are serious about AEP.

AGENT PILOT \$38/month	AGENT PRO \$68/month	AGENCY \$83/month
Solo independent agent AEP launch special	Full features + Voice AI when live	Multi-agent teams White label ready
Script Desk Launch Kit Calendar Basic CRM	Everything in Pilot + GPT Voice (coming) + Advanced CRM + Carrier Tools	Everything in Pro + Team Dashboard + Agency Reporting + Priority Support
Annual: \$368/yr (Save \$88 — 2 mo free)	Annual: \$658/yr (Save \$158 — 2 mo free)	Annual: \$803/yr (Save \$193 — 2 mo free)

- Script Desk — Medicare scripts by product & situation
- Agent Launch Kit — all 5 briefs + 100+ questions
- Fresh Pour — agent community & audio lounge
- Training Calendar — built-in appointment by block
- Book of Business CRM — track your U.S. agents
- GPT Voice AI — hands-free in the car (coming Q1 2027)
- Download & share tools
- U.S. carrier reference library
- CMS compliance reminders built in

■ 7-DAY FREE TRIAL — NO CREDIT CARD REQUIRED

Try the full app free for 7 days. No obligation. No credit card. Cancel anytime. Pilot pricing locked in for early adopters during AEP 2026. Download the Medicare Advantage Launch Blueprint PDF for just \$4.99 — or get it FREE with your 7-day trial.

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